Second Person

Second-person point of view is used occasionally when an outsider (*you*) becomes part of a story. It should not be confused with a writer or speaker using "you" when directly addressing an audience (*you*). Nor should it be confused with giving instructions (*drive forward, add one cup of brown sugar, close the door*) or with its similar use in textbooks such as this one. However, second person is not considered appropriate in most academic writing.

Writers often slip into second person when they intend to write in third person. In the example below, the writer starts in third person and shifts by accident to second person. To check your sentences for second person, search your documents for *you*, and revise as needed.

> **Shift from Third Person to Second Person** The federal government should raise the minimum wage because it has the responsibility to ensure people earn a wage you can live on. The current minimum wage, $7.25 per hour, is not enough to pay rent, let alone support a family. Many people cannot lift themselves out of poverty. A higher minimum wage can help you.
>
> **Revised** The federal government should raise the minimum wage because it has the responsibility to ensure workers earn a wage they can live on. The current minimum wage, $7.25 per hour, is not enough to pay a single person's rent, let alone support a family. Many people cannot lift themselves out of poverty. A higher minimum wage can help them.

Third Person

The third-person point of view (*he, she, it, they*) is customary for fiction and for academic writing, such as research papers, reports, visual and textual analysis papers, argumentative essays, and the like. Third-person point of view emphasizes the information instead of the writer.

> The hikers and other passive trail users argue that mountain bikes should not be allowed on narrow trails traditionally traveled by foot and horse. They point out that the bikes' wide, treaded tires cause erosion, that the bikers' high speeds startle hikers and horses, and that their presence on trails disrupts the tranquility that hikers and bird watchers seek.

H 7. Verbs

In a sentence, a verb expresses an action, an occurrence, or a state of being.

Subject-Verb Agreement

In many sentences, making the verb agree with the subject is straightforward: *I run every day. My sister runs every other day. Sometimes our brother joins us, and all of us run together.* However, subject-verb agreement gets tricky in the following circumstances. (See Editing Focus: Subject-Verb Agreement for more on subject-verb agreement.)

Agreement with Compound Subjects

Two or more subjects joined by *and* take a plural verb in most sentences:

> Yoga and meditation are effective activities for relieving stress.

However, when the parts of the subject form a single idea or unit, the verb is singular:

> Macaroni and cheese is my favorite meal.

When compound subjects are joined by *or* or *nor,* the verb agrees with the word closest to it:

> Either your aunts or your mother remembers where your great-grandmother's grave is located.
>
> Neither the image nor the words convey the message of the advertisement clearly.

Agreement When Words Come between Subject and Verb

The verb must agree with the subject even when words and phrases come between them:

The cost of the flights is prohibitive.

A box of invitations with stamps and return addresses was on the desk.

Agreement When the Verb Comes Before the Subject

The verb must agree with the subject, even when it comes before the subject:

Are James and Tamara at the front of the line?

There were three people ahead of us in line.

Under the table are a newspaper and a magazine.

Agreement with *Everyone* and Other Indefinite Pronouns

An indefinite pronoun is general; it does not refer to a specific person, place, or thing. Most indefinite pronouns take a singular verb, but not all. Those that take a singular verb include *anybody, anyone, anything, each, everybody, everyone, everything, nobody, no one, nothing, one, somebody, someone,* and *something*.

Everyone in the class has prepared a research proposal.

Nobody among the accused suspects admits to the crime.

The following indefinite pronouns take a plural verb: *both, few many, others,* and *several.*

Several of the students in the class have proposed researching hurricanes.

Both of the suspects deny committing the crime.

Several indefinite pronouns take a singular or plural verb depending on whether the word they refer to is singular or plural. These include *all, any, enough, more, most, neither, none,* and *some.*

Most of the class has proposed researching a topic related to climate change. (*Most* refers to *class.*)

Most of the students in the class have proposed researching a topic related to climate change. (*Most* refers to *students.*)

Neither the students nor the teachers have proposed a field trip. (*Neither/nor* refers to *students* and *teachers.*)

Agreement with Collective Nouns

Collective nouns such as *audience, band, class, crowd, family, group,* or *team* can take a singular or a plural verb depending on the context. When the group acts as a single unit, which is the most common construction, use a singular verb:

The band rehearses every day.

When the group acts individually, use a plural verb, or to avoid confusion, add the word *members* and use a plural verb.

The jury do not agree on a verdict.

The jury members do not agree on a verdict.

Agreement with Words Such as *News* and *Statistics*

Some nouns that end in *-s*, such as *athletics, economics, measles, news, physics, politics,* and *statistics* seem plural but are usually regarded as singular in meaning. In most situations, these words take a singular verb:

Day after day, the news was bad.

Statistics fulfills a math requirement for many college majors.

When a word like *economics, politics,* or *statistics* refers to a specific situation, use a plural verb:

The economics of the situation are hard to comprehend.

Agreement with Titles and Words Used as Words

Whether singular or plural in form, titles and words used as words take singular verbs:

Directed by Spike Lee, *Da 5 Bloods* centers around four veterans returning to Vietnam to find the remains of their squad leader and the fortune they hid together.

Children is the plural form of *child*.

Verb Tense

Tense expresses the time of a verb's action—the past, present, or future. Tense comes naturally in speech, but it can be tricky to control in writing. The following guidelines will help you choose the appropriate tense for your writing and use it consistently. (See Editing Focus: Verb Tense Consistency for a related discussion of consistent verb tense.)

Verb Tense in Narrative Writing

Personal experience stories, such as literacy narratives, memoirs, personal essays, or profiles, can be written in either the past or the present tense. Although the most natural way to tell a story about a past experience is to write in the past tense, the present tense can draw readers into the story and give the illusion that the experience is happening as they are reading it. In the following examples, the writer describes driving with her Native American grandfather to a tribal conference. Notice the difference between the past and present tense.

Narrative Writing Using Past Tense I sat silently next to Grandfather and watched him slowly tear the thin white paper from the tip of the cigarette. He gathered the tobacco in one hand and drove the van with the other. I memorized his every move as he went through the motions of the prayer, which ended when he blew the tobacco out the window and into the wind.

Narrative Writing Using Present Tense I sit silently next to Grandfather and watch him slowly tear the thin white paper from the tip of the cigarette. He gathers the tobacco in one hand and drives the van with the other. I memorize his every move as he goes through the motions of the prayer, which ends when he blows the tobacco out the window and into the wind.

Verb Tense in Academic Writing

Academic disciplines differ in their tense preferences for signal phrases used in formal essays and reports to introduce and discuss evidence. A **signal phrase** is a verb that tells readers the words or ideas that follow come from another source. Signal phrases include words such as *argues, asserts, claims, comments, denies, discusses, implies, proposes, says, shows, states,* and *suggests.* (For more discussion and a more extensive list of signal phrases, see Editing Focus: Integrating Sources and Quotations.)

acknowledges	declares	observes
admits	endorses	poses
agrees	explains	posits

TABLE H5

argues	finds	proposes
asserts	grants	reports
believes	illustrates	reveals
claims	implies	says
comments	insists	shows
concedes	maintains	states
concludes	notes	suggests
thinks	writes	

TABLE H5

If you are writing for a course in English, a foreign language, or a related discipline and using MLA documentation style, you generally will use the present tense or the present perfect tense in signal phrases.

Present Tense The film critic Manohla Dargis claims that . . .

Present Perfect Tense The film critic Manohla Dargis has claimed that . . .

When you are analyzing a work of literature, common practice is to use the literary present tense in discussing both the work of the author and the action that occurs in the work:

Being cool is key to the lives of the speakers in "We Real Cool," a poem by Gwendolyn Brooks. Brooks uses short lines and stanzas in which speakers list what it means to be cool: dropping out of school, staying out late, playing pool, drinking, carousing, and so on. Being cool unites the speakers, and they celebrate their lifestyle, even as they acknowledge in the final line of the poem that their coolness may cause them to die young.

(For more on literary present tense, see Editing Focus: Literary Works Live in the Present.)

If you are writing for a course in history, art history, philosophy, religion, or a related discipline in the humanities, you generally will use the present tense or the present perfect tense in signal phrases.

Present Tense The historian Eduardo Galeano argues that . . .

Present Perfect Tense The historian Eduardo Galeano has argued that . . .

On the other hand, if you are writing for a course in the social sciences, such as psychology, political science, or economics; a course in the natural sciences, such as biology, chemistry, or physics; or a technical field such as engineering, you will generally use past tense or present perfect tense for most signal phrases.

Past Tense The study found that individuals who identify as transgender . . . (past tense)

Present Perfect Tense: Several recent studies have found that individuals who identify as transgender . . .

Verb Tense Consistency

Whichever tense you choose, be consistent throughout a piece of writing. You may need to shift tenses to indicate actual changes in time, but the governing tense should remain constant. (See Editing Focus: Verb Tense Consistency for a related discussion of consistent verb tense.)

Inconsistent Blinking back tears, I clutched my two-year-old son to my chest, kiss his forehead, and

will gather my things. It is 2003, and I was headed to active duty in Iraq with the National Guard. I hug my spouse, my mom, my dad, my brothers, and my grandma. Then I turn and climbed on the bus that takes me to a future that, in all honesty, was terrifying to me.

Consistent Blinking back tears, I clutched my two-year-old son to my chest, kissed his forehead, and gathered my things. It was 2003, and I was headed to active duty in Iraq with the National Guard. I hugged my spouse, my mom, my dad, my brothers, and my grandma. Then I turned and climbed on the bus that would take me to a future that, in all honesty, was terrifying to me.

Irregular Verbs

Most verbs are **regular** and form the past tense and past participle forms by adding *-d* or *-ed.*

I bake/I baked/I have baked
She discovers/she discovered/she has discovered
They shovel/they shoveled/they have shoveled

Some verbs, however, are **irregular** and form the past tense and participle in another way. Below are a few of the approximately 200 irregular verbs in English. For a comprehensive list of irregular verbs, see this list (https://openstax.org/r/this_list).

begin/began/begun
bring/brought/brought
buy/bought/bought
do/did/done
drive/drove/driven
fall/fell/fallen
go/went/gone
have/had/had
is/was/been
lead/led/led
hide/hid/hidden
ring/rang/rung
run/ran/run
see/saw/seen
sing/sang/sung
sit/sat/sat
shake/shook/shaken
speak/spoke/spoken
take/took/taken
wear/wore/worn
write/wrote/written

Verb Mood

Verbs have three moods: indicative, imperative, and subjunctive. **Mood** can be said to indicate a speaker's attitude or intention.

Indicative Mood

Use the **indicative mood** to state a fact or an opinion or to ask a question:

Thousands of women currently serve in the military.

I think college tuition is expensive.

The weather was awful for much of the winter but will improve soon.

Have you submitted your request for time off?

Imperative Mood

Use the **imperative mood** to give instructions and commands. The subject, *you*, is often implied but not stated:

(You) Use the online form to request time off.

(You) Submit your request for time off by Friday.

You must submit your request on time.

Subjunctive Mood

Use the **subjunctive mood** to express wishes, suggestions, or requirements or to state hypothetical or unlikely conditions:

The rules state that every member be present for the vote.

I wish you were here to see the exhibition.

The governing board could be more effective if all members were active.

Students who failed the class would have passed had they completed all assignments.

H 8. Pronouns

A **Pronouns** is a word used in place of a noun. Some pronouns are *I, you, he, she, we, they, who,* and *everyone*. The noun a pronoun replaces or refers to is its **antecedent**. (See Editing Focus: Pronouns for a related discussion of pronouns.)

Pronoun Reference

A pronoun should refer to a clear and specific antecedent.

Clear Antecedent All nine members of the school board voted in favor of changing the district's mascot. They explained their reasoning during the meeting. (*They* refers clearly to *members.*)

Unclear Antecedent In Smith's essay, she explains why many American families have less money saved and more debt than families in the 1970s.

Revised In her essay, Smith explains why many American families have less money saved and more debt than families in the 1970s.

Problems with pronoun reference occur in the following situations:

Vague *this, that, which,* or *it.* The pronouns *this, that, which,* and *it* should not refer to words expressing an idea, an event, or a situation.

Vague Reference The school board voted to change the district's mascot without holding special meetings with the public. This made some community members angry. (*Are community members angry about the vote or about the lack of special meetings?*)

Revised The school board voted to change the district's mascot without holding special meetings with the public. Their decision to avoid public discussion before the vote made some community members angry.

Indefinite *it, they,* or *you.* The pronouns *it, they,* and *you* should have a definite antecedent in a sentence.

Indefinite *it* Crittenden explains that mothers are taken for granted and disrespected, even though our society calls it the most important job in the world.

Revised Crittenden explains that mothers are taken for granted and disrespected, even though our